

5 New Ways to Hack Your Boss (without a Machete)



When I started my first “real job,” I didn’t realize how many situations I’d find myself in that were utterly different from most of what I’d encountered before. On top of learning the tasks specific to the job, I had to navigate office politics and figure out what it meant to be “professional.” I had to make decisions about these things on the fly, without any experience and with only my intuition to guide me. I made a few mistakes while I figured it out, but eventually I learned to survive and thrive. While I’m still no expert, what I offer here are hacks to common problems that have worked for me and for those I know.

Note: These hacks will be particularly relevant to entry-level po-

sitions, but could be useful at other times, as well.

WHEN YOU’VE JUST FINISHED A PROJECT:

Let your boss know you’re thinking about the future. Either ask him, “So, what’s next?” or let him know you’ll be needing some time to get things together before he approaches you with the next project. Something like, “I’m getting ready for the next project. Could we talk about it in an hour / this afternoon / tomorrow / next week after I tie up some loose ends? I’ve been focusing on getting this done but want to make sure I haven’t let anything fall through the cracks.” Both approaches let him know that you’re focused on what is best for the company. The second allows you to look this way but gives you the break you need when the project you’ve been working your butt off to finish is finally done.

WHEN SHE’S POINTING OUT YOUR LITTLE MISTAKES (AGAIN!):

Remember that this is part of her job, and may be as distasteful to her as it is to you (or may not, depending on the boss). If the criticism is particularly difficult for you to hear, remember to breathe before you say anything. A deep breath or so, when done surreptitiously, can give you the strength to